Lambe beginner user guide

Reading Tengwar and using Lambe on Windows and Android

You can begin with ordinary English. Lambe changes the writing system while leaving your words in the same language. This guide teaches the shapes and reading conventions first, then shows how to edit your result, create modes and make a font.



English cat. The three-dot a is written above the following consonant, t.

The words used in this guide

A tengwa is a base letter; tengwar is the plural. A tehta is an added mark; tehtar is the plural. A vowel tehta represents a vowel. Other tehtar modify consonants. A carrier supports a vowel mark without adding a consonant sound.

A mode assigns meanings to the shapes and tells you how to read them. A font supplies their visual design. One tengwa can represent different sounds in different modes, so always read it using the chosen mode.

Your first result

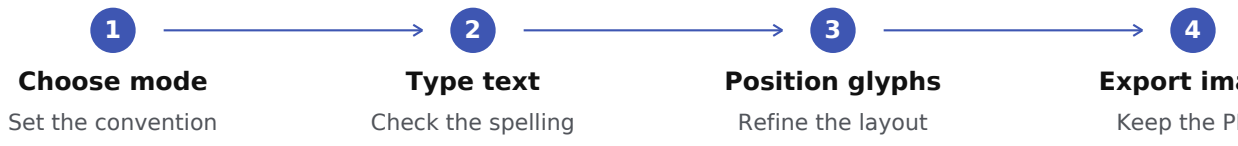
1 Open Lambe On Windows, extract the whole ZIP and open Lambe.exe. On Android, open the APK and allow installation from your download app if asked.

2 Choose English In 1. Source input, set Writing mode to English and type cat. Your result appears automatically in 2. Tengwar output.

3 Keep a result Choose Export image to save a PNG. You can share the picture without asking the recipient to install a Tengwar font.

Use pages 2–3 for reading order; pages 4–6 for English; pages 7–8 for Quenya; pages 9–10 for Sindarin; page 11 for exceptions; and pages 12–16 for the app tools.

From text to a finished image



Understanding reading order

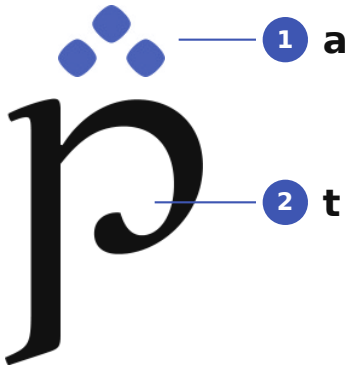
Read the line from left to right. For an ordinary short vowel, English and Sindarin place the vowel sign on the following consonant; Quenya places it on the preceding consonant. This changes the order in which you read each group.

One written shape Two reading orders

English and Sindarin

Following consonant

Input at

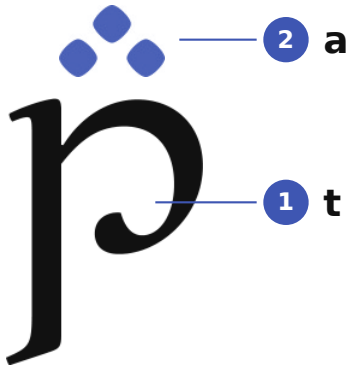


Read a then t

Quenya

Preceding consonant

Input ta



Read t then a

The line still runs from left to right



group 1 group 2

Complete one group before moving to the next.

Reading-order comparison. The positions give a first orientation; not every mark represents a separately read vowel.

First identify what each mark means. A nasal bar supplies a consonant before its base; a doubling bar repeats it; a silent-e dot is not pronounced. Skip a position when no mark is present. Carriers and diphthongs need the special readings on page 11.

Comparing the same name

Gandalf makes the attachment difference visible. The two a vowels move to different hosts. The consonant sequence also reflects the mode: Sindarin writes nd with a nasal bar over ando; Quenya gives ando the value nd without that extra bar.

Sindarin tehta mode



g · a-nd · a-l · f

Vowels before their host

Quenya mode



ga · nda · l · f

Vowels after their host

Both rows show a final /f/ using formen. The same name illustrates placement; it is not a translation into either language.

How to reproduce the example in Lambe

Quenya: select Quenya and enter Gandalf. Read ga, nda, l, f. The first a sits over ungwe and the second sits over ando. Plain g is an allowance for a borrowed name, rather than an ordinary Quenya consonant in native words.

Sindarin: select Sindarin and enter Gandalff for the /f/ ending shown here. Read g, a-nd, a-l, f. The a signs sit over the following nd and l. Two marks appear above nd: the nasal bar and the vowel sign.

In the bundled Sindarin profile, final single f means /v/ and produces ampa. Final ff keeps /f/ and produces formen. If you enter Gandalf with one f, that final glyph changes. This input convention matters for borrowed names.

Sindarin at



Quenya ta



A simpler contrast: tinco with a above reads at in Sindarin and ta in Quenya. Choose the mode before reading the group.

Do not select an Elvish language mode simply to give English words an Elvish appearance. For ordinary English writing, begin with English and adjust a custom copy when needed.

English tengwar table

These are the 36 core tengwar with Lambe’s English assignments. A glyph name identifies its shape. The value describes input or a sound in this mode. No usual input means the shape remains available for manual work or custom modes.

 **tinco** t	 **parma** p	**calma** ch as in church	**quesse** c / k; q alone
 **ando** d	**umbar** b	 **anga** j	**ungwe** hard g
thuule th as in thin	**formen** f	**harma** sh	**hwesta** No usual input
 **anto** th as in this; dh	 **ampa** v	**anca** zh sound	 **unque** gh in ghost
 **nuumen** n	**malta** m	 **noldo** No usual input	 **nwalme** ng as in ring
 **oore** r before consonant / at end	 **vala** w	 **anna** consonantal y; diphthongs	 **vilya** No usual input
 **roomen** r before sounded vowel	 **arda** No usual input	 **lambe** l	 **alda** ll
 **silme** s	 **silme-nuquerna** s turned; soft c	 **esse** z; some voiced s	**esse-nuquerna** z turned
 **hyarmen** h	 **hwesta-sindarinwa** wh	**yanta** No usual input	**uure** No usual input

Soft c occurs before e, i or y, with exceptions. Context chooses R and some TH, CH, NG and S forms. Turned S and Z keep their letter value while making space for marks. Extra letters, carriers and common combinations appear on pages 5–6.

English vowels and vowel groups

Lambe’s English mode is mainly orthographic: the vowels normally record spelling rather than one fixed pronunciation. In cat, a is the same vowel letter as in many other spellings, even when its spoken sound differs.

Input	Tehta	Shape	On a short carrier
a		three dots	
e		slanting stroke	
i		one dot	
o		right curl	
u		left curl	

Vowels attach to the following consonant. A final sounded vowel, or a vowel without a suitable next host, uses a carrier. Vocalic y uses the breve-shaped mark; consonantal y before a vowel uses anna. Silent e uses a dot below the preceding base, so it is not read as an extra syllable.

Input or group	Example glyph	Meaning in the English profile
vowel y		Breve-shaped mark, distinct from the Quenya y underdots
ai / ei / oi / ui		anna carries the first vowel mark; ai is shown
au / eu / iu / ou		vala carries the first vowel mark; au is shown
ea		osse with the e mark
ae / oe		carrier with the first vowel and a dot below; ae is shown
oo / ee and others		Repeated vowel marks remain distinct and can sit side by side

ay, ey and oy join the anna group; aw, ew and ow join the vala group. Lambe uses spelling and word exceptions to choose combinations. An apostrophe can separate vowel input that should stay separate, as in archa'ic. For two separate repeated-vowel carriers, try oo* or ee*.

A host or a carrier

at → 
a attaches to t
one written group

ta → 
a needs a carrier
no following host

English consonant marks and shortcuts

Many letter sequences form one group. Identify the consonant modification before reading a vowel that shares the group. A bar is not another vowel.

Input or feature	Glyph example	How to read it
nt / nd		n before t or d; nt is shown
mp / mb		m before p or b; mp is shown
nk / hard nc		n before k; soft c can prevent this combination
ng		ng as in ring; hard ng can use ungwe with a nasal bar
qu / qw / kw		A w modification of the k letter
doubled consonant		Bar below repeats the consonant; tt is shown
final s		A curl supplies s after the base
silent e		A spelling mark below; do not add a spoken vowel
the		A whole-word shorthand
of		A whole-word shorthand
and		A whole-word shorthand
we		Lambe’s supplied shorthand convention

of the adds a bar below the of shorthand. PH uses extended-parma; TH pronounced /t/ in words such as Thomas uses extended-tinco; hard CH uses extended-quesse. Silent GH can use extended-ungwe. CK is quesse with a doubling bar. X combines a consonant with an s-like curl below.

Names and unusual pronunciations may need correction. To write final s as a separate letter, try s* at the end. For recurring changes, duplicate English and change its inherited rules. The original built-in mode stays available.

The bar changes the consonant

n + t → 

Nasal bar above

Read n before t

t + t → 

Bar below

Read doubled t

Quenya tengwar table

The Quenya profile uses the classical arrangement. Ordinary vowel signs belong to the preceding consonant. The same shapes can have different values from English: ando is nd, anto is nt, and vala is v.

 **tinco** t	 **parma** p	 **calma** c / k	 **quesse** qu / kw
 ando nd; loan d	 **umbar** mb; loan b	 **anga** ng	 **ungwe** ngw; loan g
 **thuule** th / þ; historical s	 **formen** f / ph	 **harma** medial h	 **hwesta** hw
 **anto** nt	 **ampa** mp	 **anca** nc / nk	 **unque** nqu
 **nuumen** n	 **malta** m	 **noldo** ñ	 **nwalme** ñw; special nw
 **oore** r before consonant / at end	 **vala** v	 **anna** y with underdots	 **vilya** w
 **roomen** r before vowel	 **arda** rd	 **lambe** l	 **alda** ld
 **silme** s	 **silme-nuquerna** s turned	 **esse** ss	 **esse-nuquerna** ss turned
 **hyarmen** h before vowel	 **hwesta-sindarinwa** No usual input	 **yanta** i-ending diphthongs	 **uure** u-ending diphthongs

c and k both represent the /k/ sound. qu consumes the u as part of /kw/. Historical th may survive in spellings that now sound like s. Plain b, d and g are also accepted for borrowed input; their presence does not make them ordinary native Quenya sounds.

Quenya vowels and combinations

Use the same five main vowel signs. Read an ordinary consonant first and its vowel sign afterwards. A word-initial vowel has no preceding consonant, so it needs a carrier.

Input	Tehta	Vowel	On a short carrier
a		three dots	
e		slanting stroke	
i		one dot	
o		right curl	
u		left curl	

A short carrier has no consonant sound. Long á, é, í, ó and ú use long-carrier forms in the default profile; aa, ee, ii, oo and uu are accepted as long-vowel input too. Diaeresis in ë does not make a different vowel: Lambe reads it as e.

Diphthong input	Glyph	Components
ai		a sign with yanta for the i ending
oi		o sign with yanta
ui		u sign with yanta
au		a sign with uure for the u ending
eu		e sign with uure
iu		i sign with uure

Consonantal y and doubled letters

Two dots below add a y modification to a consonant: ty, ny, my and ry are examples. When y has no consonant host, anna with underdots supplies it. In tya, read t + y + a, even though the y mark is below and a is above. The numbered box rule alone cannot explain this group.

Doubled consonants normally add a bar below; ll uses a bar inside lambe and ss uses esse. R before a vowel uses roomen; final R and R before another consonant generally use oore. The profile includes historical spelling exceptions. Use the output as a starting point when a name or spelling needs review.

Sindarin tengwar table

This is the supplied Sindarin tehta mode, not the Mode of Beleriand. Ordinary vowels belong to the following consonant and are read before it. Beleriand uses separate vowel letters and needs its own table.

 **tinco** t	 **parma** p	 **calma** nc / nk with nasal bar	 **quesse** c / k
 **ando** d	 **umbar** b	 **anga** No usual input	 **ungwe** g
 thuule th / þ	 **formen** f / ph; ff	 **harma** No usual input	 **hwesta** ch as in loch
 anto dh / ð	 **ampa** v; final f	 **anca** No usual input	 **unque** No usual input
 **nuumen** n	 **malta** m	 **noldo** No usual input	 **nwalme** ñ; initial ng
 **oore** final r	 **vala** w; au / aw	 **anna** ai / ei / ui	 **vilya** No usual input
 **roomen** r elsewhere	 **arda** initial rh	 **lambe** l	 **alda** initial lh
 **silme** s	 **silme-nuquerna** s turned	 **esse** ss variant	 **esse-nuquerna** ss
 **hyarmen** h	 **hwesta-sindarinwa** hw	 **yanta** j; initial i + vowel; ae / oe	 **uure** No usual input

c and k have the /k/ sound. ch is the sound in loch; dh is like th in this, while th is like th in thin. Final r uses oore. Initial rh and lh use their special shapes. Some catalogue shapes serve combinations rather than a standalone input letter.

Sindarin vowels and combinations

Sindarin uses the same five vowel signs plus a sixth for y. This y is a vowel; the two dots are above, unlike the Quenya consonantal-y dots below.

Input	Tehta	Vowel	On a short carrier
a		three dots	
e		slanting stroke	
i		one dot	
o		right curl	
u		left curl	
y		two dots above	

Read the vowel before the following consonant. A final vowel needs a carrier. Long vowels such as â, ê, î, ô, û and ŷ use a long carrier. Acute forms such as á and repeated aa are also recognised as long-vowel input for the five main vowels.

Diphthong input	Glyph	Components
ae		a sign with yanta
oe		o sign with yanta
ai		a sign with anna
ei		e sign with anna
ui		u sign with anna
au		a sign with vala

The last row also accepts aw. Initial i before a vowel can be a consonantal glide written with yanta. Nasal bars add n or m; gw and dw use a w modification. A bar inside lambe doubles l; bars can also double m, n and r.

Final single f is /v/ and uses ampa; use ff for final /f/. This distinction explains why the Gandalf illustration uses Gandalff as its Sindarin input. Word-final ng, initial ng and an internal hard-ng sequence can also need different forms; spelling context matters.

final f →  ampa /v/

final ff →  formen /f/

Special cases beyond the arrows

The position of a mark does not tell you its meaning by itself. Decode the whole group using the mode, then place it in the left-to-right word sequence.

Quenya ai



vowel sign + vowel letter

Quenya tya



t + consonantal y + a

English nt



bar supplies n before t

English be



dot marks a silent e

Four cases where a simple top-middle-bottom scan needs more information. The marks shown are the actual forms used in Lambe.

Diphthongs

In Quenya ai, the base yanta supplies the i ending and the mark supplies a. Read ai, not ia. The base is acting as part of a vowel group rather than an ordinary consonant. Sindarin ae and ai also use vowel-group letters with their own values.

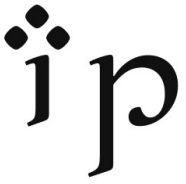
Consonant modifications

Quenya tya has two dots below for consonantal y and a above for the vowel. Read t-y-a. A nasal bar above tinco supplies n before t, producing nt. A bar below a consonant normally doubles it. These marks change how you read the consonant rather than adding a new vowel after it.

Silent spelling marks

In Lambe’s English be, the dot below umbar records the supplied silent-e convention. It is not a second spoken vowel. A final-s curl supplies s after a base even when the curl sits to its side or below it.

Quenya at



Sindarin ta



Long vowel á

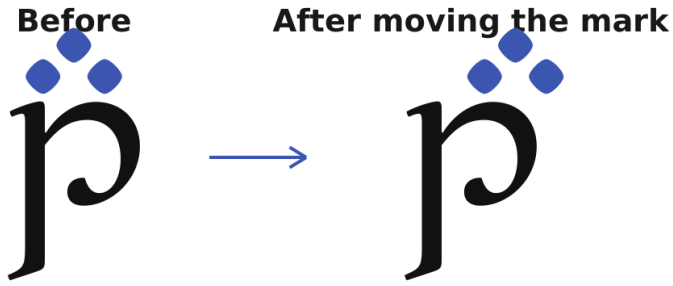


Carriers have no consonant sound. Quenya at begins with one; Sindarin ta ends with one. A long carrier distinguishes a long vowel.

Turned letters and manual movement do not automatically change the spelling. A turned silme is still s. If you drag a vowel sign below a base as a visual choice, its mode assignment remains the same. For a new writing rule, edit the mode instead.

Selecting and positioning in Lambe

Select a base or a mark in 2. Tengwar output. They are independent objects. If two marks overlap, use the labelled choices beneath the output to choose the exact one.





Select the three dots, then press 6 twice.

Only the selected mark moves. The base stays put.

8 up 2 down
4 left 6 right

The blue tehta moves independently. Select it and press 6 twice to shift it to the right.

One object or a group

Select multiple lets you choose several bases and marks. Check the selection count before moving them. Attached marks must be selected too if they should move with a base. Clear selection begins a new group.

Movement and rotation

Drag for free movement, or use the direction pad. Each press moves 0.2 unit: 8 up, 2 down, 4 left, 6 right, and the corner keys diagonally. Relative movement adds steps; Set position from centre uses the centre as the reference.

Undo move / rotation reverses the last move or turn. Clear position, or 5, clears the selection’s position adjustments. Use 90° left or 90° right to rotate the selection. Windows also accepts the physical number pad; Android’s direction pad can be opened and dismissed when needed.

Replacing and adding shapes

Browse tengwar and Browse tehtar show the catalogue. The selected-base controls let you choose another base or Add mark. Selecting a mark lets you change or delete only that mark. Upright and Nuquerna let you choose an S or Z form manually.

Make source-text and mode changes before detailed placement: changing the mode regenerates the result. Source edits can preserve unchanged objects, but keep an exported image of a finished layout you do not want to lose. Enter preserves new lines and blank lines.

Selection count determines what moves



Selected 1

Mark only

The base stays put



Selected 2

Base and mark

Move the whole group

Creating a custom writing mode

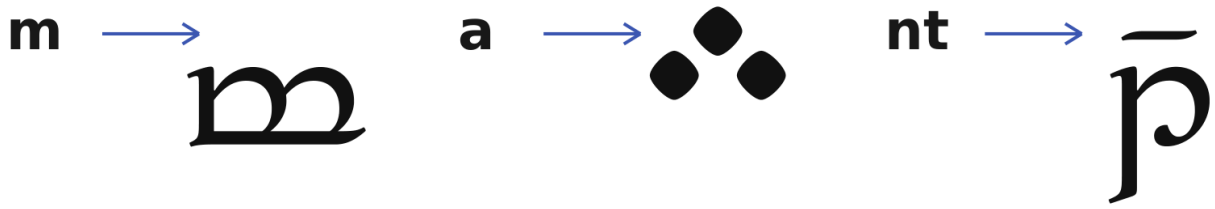
Use a custom mode for a convention you want to apply repeatedly. The canvas controls adjust one composition; a mode changes what future input produces.

1 Create your own mode Choose Start from. Standard starts with English behaviour; Empty starts with no associations; an existing mode creates an independent copy.

2 Name the copy Give it a recognisable name. Change a few things at a time and use Try your mode to see the result.

3 Add an association Use Add tengwa or Add tehta. Enter Input text, choose the shape and, for a mark, choose Placement. Then Save association.

4 Save and select Choose Save mode, return to Writing mode and select your copy. Export mode makes a backup or a definition another user can import.



One base	One mark	Base with a mark
Add tengwa	Add tehta	Add tehta to association

An input can produce a base, a mark, or a combination. These shapes remain separate editable objects in the output.

A small practice mode

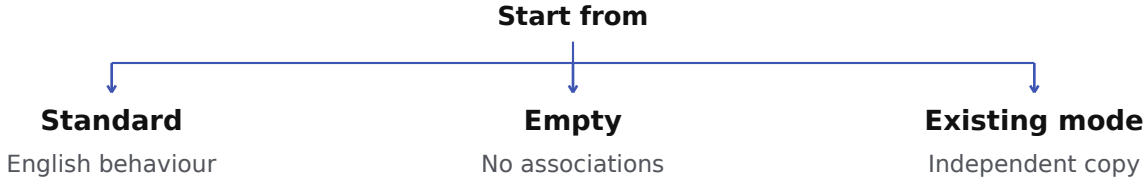
Create an Empty mode named Practice. Add m as malta, b as umbar, and a as the three-dot tehta placed Above. Mark a as a vowel and keep Tehtar attach to the following tengwa on. Try ab: the a sign belongs above umbar. Try mb to see two plain bases.

Combined output and classification

Add tehta to association attaches one or more marks to a base mapping. For nt, choose tinco and a nasalBar Above. Add tengwa to association can turn a mark mapping into a combined output.

This input represents a vowel affects the R rule. It is independent of whether the output is a full letter or a mark. Use Find an association to locate a mapping. A switch disables it temporarily; the bin removes it. Longer matching associations take priority over shorter ones.

Choose a starting point for your mode



Contextual rules and silent markers

Use Add rule when output depends on position or neighbouring input. A rule can supply a base, marks only, or a base with marks. Custom rules take priority over ordinary associations.

mb



m inside the word stays unchanged

bm



final m receives the dot below

A custom final-m convention. Only the m at the end of bm receives a dot below. This is a teaching example, not a universal Tengwar rule.

1 Match m In Practice, choose Add rule and enter m in Match this input. Set Where to End of word.

2 Choose malta Leave Tehtar only and Add marks to preceding tengwa off, then choose malta as Output tengwa.

3 Add the dot Choose Add tehta to rule, select dotBelow and set Placement to Below. Save rule, test mb and bm, then Save mode.

Other conditions and attachments

Where also offers Anywhere, Whole word, Start of word, Before input and After input. For Before or After, enter alternatives in Surrounding input separated by commas, such as a,e,i,o,u. The neighbouring text is checked without being consumed.

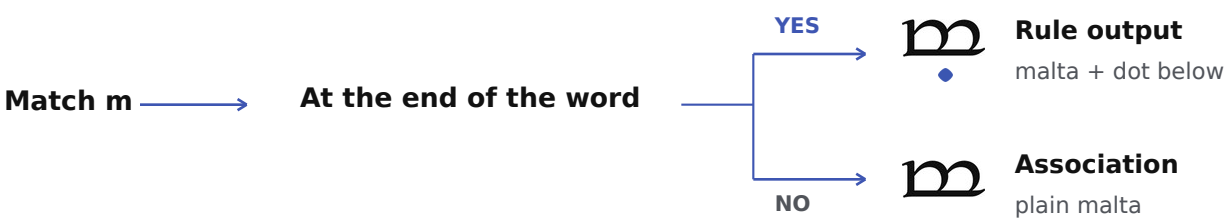
Tehtar only follows the mode's normal attachment direction. Add marks to preceding tengwa explicitly uses the previous object. A carrier is supplied when there is no suitable host. When two rules match, longer input takes priority; equally long rules use their list order.

Invisible input

Add no output consumes a control symbol without drawing a shape or space. For a silent ^ marker that classifies the preceding input as a vowel, enable Classify the preceding input and Treat preceding input as a vowel. With r and b mapped and R rule on, compare rb and rb^.

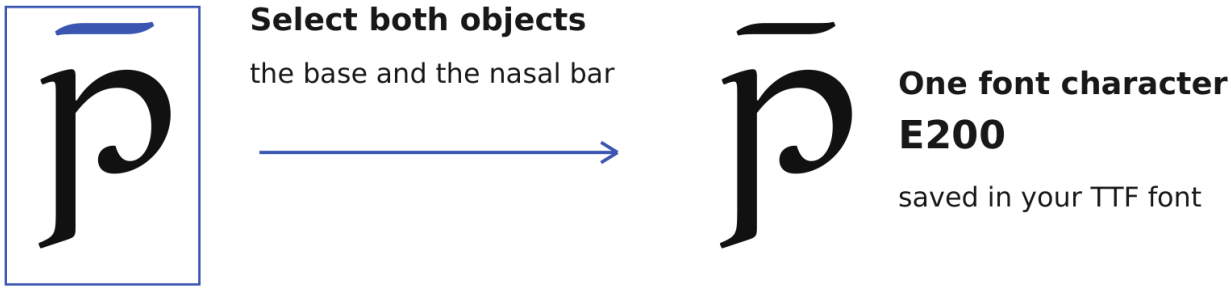
Keep Automatically flip S / SS / Z on for automatic turned forms. Turn R rule off for a fixed R mapping, or delete it and write your own contextual rules. Standard and English copies also expose inherited rule groups. Check those when a new association seems to be ignored.

The final m rule in the Practice mode



Turning a selection into a font glyph

5. Selection to font glyph combines selected outlines into one typeable character. This keeps a custom letter or carefully arranged group available in another application as text.



The base and mark become one character in your font. E200 is an example private-use character address.

1 Compose and select Enable Select multiple and choose every required base and mark. Check the selection count.

2 Choose a font New font starts a small font; Use bundled font starts with the supplied glyph set. Import font opens a supported existing font to extend.

3 Name the glyph Set Font family and Glyph name, for example myNasalT. The glyph name is a label inside the font, not the word typed into the main input.

4 Choose a character Use an unused Character code (hex), such as E200. Leave replacement off unless you intend to replace an existing mapping.

5 Add and preview Choose Add selection as glyph. Begin with Scale at 100, Baseline shift at 0 and Advance width blank. Inspect the font preview.

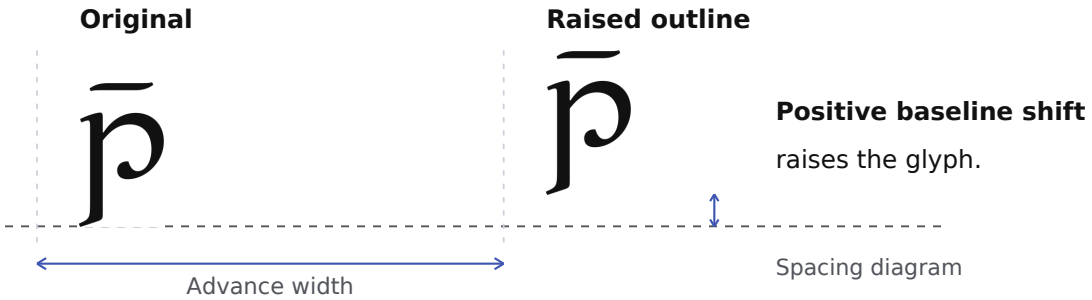
6 Save and use Choose Save font (.ttf). Install or load it where you want to type, select that font, and use Copy glyph character to insert the assigned character.

Spacing and continuing later

Scale changes the size. Positive Baseline shift raises the glyph. Advance width sets the space before the next character, including side space. Change one setting at a time.

Save before closing Lambe, choosing New font or importing another font. Reimport your TTF to continue later. Static TTF is the simplest import choice on Android. Importing a font here does not change the main canvas font. Share your TTF with the characters and retain the relevant font licence and attribution.

Font spacing and baseline shift



Keeping work and learning further

What each saved file keeps

Export image saves a PNG of the result, including manual placement and line breaks. Keep the input text separately too. Export mode saves your convention’s mappings and rules; it does not preserve the current canvas composition. Save font (.ttf) keeps the working font for later reimport.

Export modes and save fonts before updating or uninstalling. Keep the whole Windows app folder together. Clearing Android app storage or uninstalling can remove saved modes. The alpha does not automatically reopen a complete composition or unsaved font work.

Other supplied modes and numbers

Beleriand is a full-vowel mode: its ordinary vowels are base letters rather than the five vowel signs taught here. German, Romanised Hebrew and Arabic Arabizi have their own assignments. Their names appear in Writing mode; duplicate a profile to adapt it.

Arabizi uses inputs such as 3 and 7 as consonants. Prefix an actual number with a backslash, such as \2026. The tengwar numerals switch chooses ordinary or Tengwar digit shapes. Lambe retains the entered digit order and does not convert numbers to base twelve.

If something looks wrong

Check Writing mode first, then the input and any rule that controls it. Use the labelled selections when the wrong object moves. Use a free character address and selected outlines when font creation fails. For feedback, include the device, mode, exact input, expected result and a picture. Attach a custom mode export when needed.

Lambe downloads and user feedback

Reading references and credits

The tables and typing instructions describe Lambe 0.9.6 defaults, including its English spelling exceptions. They are not a claim that every Tolkien inscription uses the same choices. Reading-order diagrams introduce ordinary vowel attachment. The glyph examples use Lambe’s bundled Alcarin Tengwar outlines by Toshi Omagari, under the SIL Open Font License.

The Classical Mode by Måns Björkman

Writing Sindarin with Tengwar by Per Lindberg

Lambe was created by André I. Ben, Lambe Labs. Tolkien created the Tengwar writing system. Keep applicable font notices when sharing fonts derived from the bundled outlines.

Keep the file that matches your work

